The Language of College

A Reading, Writing & Communication Toolkit

Offline edition, made on October 18, 2026.

The newest version is on the website: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/

Contents

Understand the assignment

- Understanding a Writing Prompt
- Task Verbs: Analyze, Compare, Evaluate
- Reading a Rubric

Take part in class

- Writing a Discussion Post
- Replying to Classmates

Grammar for college writing

- Articles: A, An, The

Ask for help

- Working with a Tutor

Instructor Companion

- Writing a Clear Assignment Prompt
- Setting Expectations for Discussions and Journals
- Assignment Prompt Builder
- Rubrics and Where Language Accuracy Fits

Understand the assignment

UNDERSTAND THE ASSIGNMENT

Understanding a Writing Prompt

Use this page when your instructor gives you a writing assignment and you want to be sure what it asks you to do.

Online: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/assignments/writing-prompt.html

What a prompt tells you

A **writing prompt** is the set of instructions for a writing assignment. Your grade depends on doing what the prompt asks, so read it slowly, at least two times, before you start to write.

Good writers at every level sometimes answer a different question than the one the prompt asked. A careful reading prevents that. As you read, look for the answers to five questions.

1. **What do I do?** Find the task verb, such as explain, compare, or argue.
2. **What do I write about?** Find the topic and any limits on the topic.
3. **Who is my reader?** Some prompts name a reader. If the prompt does not, write for a reader who has not taken your class.
4. **What are the requirements?** Find the length, the number of sources, and the format.
5. **How do I finish?** Find the due date, the place to submit your work, and how it will be graded.

If the prompt does not answer one of these questions, ask your instructor. That is a normal and useful question.

KEY TERMS

Writing prompt: the instructions for a writing assignment.

Task verb: the verb that names the kind of thinking and writing you must do.

Rubric: a chart that shows how your work will be graded.

Example: reading a prompt closely

Here is a prompt from a first-year writing course. Six phrases are highlighted. Each number matches a note below the prompt.

A writing prompt with notes

Essay 2: A Change Worth Making

Think of one problem at your workplace, in your neighborhood, or at this college. (1) Write an essay that argues for one specific change (2) that would improve the situation. Your readers are the people who could make that change, (3) so explain the problem clearly and give reasons they would accept.

Support your argument with evidence from at least two credible sources. (4) Your essay should be 750–1,000 words in MLA format. (5) Submit your essay in Blackboard by the due date listed there. See the rubric (6) for how this essay will be graded.

1. **The topic, with a choice.**
   You choose the problem. The word **or** tells you to choose one of the three places, not all three.

2. **The task.**
   The task verb is **argues**. To argue is to state your position and give reasons for it. Describing the problem is not enough. The words **one specific** set a limit: write about one change, and say exactly what it is.

3. **The reader.**
   You are writing to people who have the power to make the change. Ask yourself what they already know and what reasons matter to them.

4. **A requirement with a number.**
   At least two means two or more. One source is too few. **Credible** means that readers can trust the source.

5. **Length and format.**
   Your essay needs between 750 and 1,000 words. MLA is a set of rules for how a paper looks and how it names its sources. The word **should** is a requirement here. See the language focus below.

6. **How you will be graded.**
   The rubric shows what your instructor will look for. Read it before you write, not after.

TIP

Now answer the five questions for this prompt. If you can answer all five in your own words, you understand the assignment.

Language focus: required, allowed, or not allowed

LANGUAGE FOCUS

Commands

Prompts often start a sentence with a verb: **Write an essay. Support your argument. Submit your essay.** These sentences are commands. They have no subject because the subject is always you. In a prompt, a command is not rude. It is a requirement.

Small words that change the meaning

Words such as must, should, and may tell you how much choice you have.

Words that show what is required

Words in the prompt	What they mean	Example
must **need to** **are required to**	Required.	You must name every source you use.
should **are expected to**	Required in most prompts. In conversation, should gives advice. In a prompt, treat it as a rule.	Your essay should be 750–1,000 words.
may **can** **are allowed to**	Allowed. You choose.	You may write in first person (I, my).
are encouraged to consider	A good idea, but your choice.	Consider sharing your draft with a tutor.
may not **must not** **do not**	Not allowed.	Do not use outside sources.

WATCH FOR THIS

In a prompt, **may not** means “not allowed.” It does not mean “maybe not.”

Words that set limits

- **at least two sources**: two or more.
- **no more than 1,000 words**: 1,000 words or fewer.
- **750–1,000 words**: any number from 750 to 1,000.
- **one specific change**: exactly one, described clearly.

Sentence starters: asking about a prompt

Instructors expect questions about prompts. Ask early, and say what you already understand. Fill in each blank with your own words.

TO CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

I want to check my understanding. The essay should _____. Is that correct?

TO ASK ABOUT THE PURPOSE

What skill should I practice in this assignment?

TO ASK WHAT A WORD MEANS

In the prompt, what does "_____" mean?

TO ASK ABOUT A LIMIT

Does the word count include _____?

TO ASK ABOUT YOUR TOPIC

May I write about _____ for this assignment?

TO ASK WHAT IS ALLOWED

Are we allowed to use _____ for this assignment?

Practice

Read this prompt for a discussion post. Then answer the questions.

> Read the assigned article about working from home. In one paragraph of 150–200 words, summarize the author's main argument. Then, in a second paragraph, explain whether you agree with the author. Use one example from your own experience. You may write in first person (I, my). Do not use outside sources.

1. What are the two task verbs?

2. How many paragraphs must you write?
3. Is it acceptable to write “I agree because my job changed last year”?
4. You find a helpful website about working from home. Can you quote it in your post?
5. What does the prompt not tell you?

Suggested answers

1. **Summarize and explain.**
   First you report the author’s main argument in fewer words. Then you give your own position and your reasons.
2. **Two.**
   The prompt says “one paragraph” and then “a second paragraph.”
3. **Yes.**
   “You may write in first person” means it is allowed. The prompt also asks for an example from your own experience.
4. **No.**
   “Do not use outside sources” is a command. The only source you can use is the assigned article.
5. **The length of the second paragraph, the due date, and how the post is graded.**
   These are good questions to ask. You could write: “Does the 150–200 word limit apply to the second paragraph too?”

Next step

Try this with a prompt from one of your classes

1. Highlight the task verb.
2. Underline every number and every word that sets a limit.
3. Circle any word you do not know. Look it up, or ask your instructor.

4. Write the task in one sentence: “In this assignment, I will _____ about _____ for _____.”

Related pages

Task verbs: analyze, compare, evaluate
What each common task verb asks you to do.

Reading a rubric
How to use a rubric before, during, and after you write.

FOR INSTRUCTORS **Writing a clear assignment prompt**
The Instructor Companion page that pairs with this one.

UNDERSTAND THE ASSIGNMENT

Task Verbs: Analyze, Compare, Evaluate

Use this page when a prompt uses a verb such as analyze or evaluate, and you are not sure what it asks you to do.

Online: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/assignments/task-verbs.html

Why the verb matters

A **task verb** is the word in a prompt that names the kind of thinking you must do. Two students can write about the same topic and receive very different grades, because one did what the verb asked and the other did not.

Look at one topic with three different verbs:

- **Describe the effects of social media on sleep.** Report what the effects are.
- **Explain why social media affects sleep.** Give the causes.
- **Evaluate one way to reduce the effects of social media on sleep.** Judge how well it works, and give reasons.

These are three different assignments. A strong answer to the first one would be a weak answer to the third.

CHECK YOUR COURSE FIRST

Instructors do not all use these verbs in exactly the same way. If your prompt or your instructor defines a verb, use that definition. If you are not sure, ask.

KEY TERMS

Task verb: the verb that names the kind of thinking and writing you must do.

Evidence: facts, examples, or ideas from sources that support a point.

Criteria: the standards you use to judge something. One standard is a criterion.

Three groups of verbs

Most task verbs belong to one of three groups. Each group asks for more of your own thinking than the one before it.

Group 1: Report

Say what something is or what a source says. Stay close to the facts. The prompt is not asking for your opinion.

Verbs that ask you to report

Verb	What to do
define	Give the exact meaning of a word or idea.
describe	Say what something is like. Give details.
identify	Name the thing the prompt asks about. A short answer is often enough.
summarize	Give the main ideas of a text in fewer words, in your own words.

Group 2: Show how or why

Show how ideas connect. Your thinking is visible in the connections you make.

Verbs that ask you to show how or why

Verb	What to do
explain	Make something clear by giving reasons or steps. Answer “how?” or “why?”
analyze	Break something into parts. Show how the parts work together.
compare	Show how two things are alike. Many instructors also want the differences.
contrast	Show how two things are different.
apply	Use an idea from the course in a new situation.

Group 3: Take a position

Give your own judgment or view, and support it. Your opinion is required, and so are your reasons.

Verbs that ask you to take a position

Verb	What to do
argue	State a position. Support it with reasons and evidence.
evaluate	Judge how good, useful, or true something is. Name your criteria and give reasons.
respond	Give your own reaction to a text, with reasons.
reflect	Think about your own experience or learning. Say what it means to you and what you will do next.

A VERB TO ASK ABOUT

Discuss is the least exact task verb. It usually means: look at the topic from more than one side, and then give your view. If a prompt says only "discuss," ask your instructor what the answer should include.

Example: one article, three verbs

Three students read the same article about sleep and college students. Each student had a different task verb. Here is the first part of each answer. Each number matches a note below.

Three answers with notes

Summarize

The author explains that (1) college students who sleep fewer than seven hours have more trouble remembering information. The article describes a study in which students who slept longer earned higher grades.

Analyze

The article has three parts: a claim, a study, and advice. 2 The advice depends on 3 the study. Without the study, the advice would be only the author's opinion.

Evaluate

The article is convincing but limited. 4 The evidence is strong because it comes from a study. 5 However, the study included students at only one university, so the results may not be true for all students.

1 **A summary reports.**
The words **The author explains that** show that the ideas belong to the author. The student gives no opinion.

2 **An analysis names the parts.**
The student divides the article into three parts.

3 **An analysis connects the parts.**
Depends on shows how one part is related to another. Naming the parts is not enough.

4 **An evaluation gives a judgment.**
Convincing and **limited** are judgment words. The student gives both a strength and a weakness.

5 **An evaluation gives reasons.**
The student's criterion is the quality of the evidence. **Because** and **so** connect each judgment to a reason.

Language focus: words for comparing and judging

LANGUAGE FOCUS

Signal words for each task

Words that show the kind of thinking

Task	Useful words	Example
Show a likeness	both, like, similarly, in the same way	Both courses require a final project.
Show a difference	however, while, unlike, in contrast	Online classes are flexible, while in-person classes have a fixed schedule.
Show a cause	because, so, as a result, leads to	Students sleep less, so they remember less.
Give a judgment	effective, convincing, limited, a strength, a weakness	One weakness of the plan is its cost.

Comparing with -er and more

To compare two things, change the adjective and add **than**.

- Short adjectives add -er: **cheaper than, easier than, longer than**.
- Longer adjectives use more: **more flexible than, more expensive than, more effective than**.
- Two common adjectives are irregular: **good, better** and **bad, worse**.

WATCH FOR THIS

Use -er or more, never both. Write **easier than**. Do not write “more easier than.” Also check the spelling of **than**. Then is a different word, about time.

Sentence starters

Fill in each blank with your own words.

TO SUMMARIZE

The author explains that _____.

The main idea of the article is _____.

TO ANALYZE

One important part of _____ is _____.

_____ depends on _____ because _____.

TO COMPARE AND CONTRAST

Both _____ and _____ _____.

Unlike _____, _____.

TO EVALUATE

_____ is effective because _____.

One weakness of _____ is _____.

TO ARGUE

_____ should _____ because _____.

Practice

1. The prompt says: **"Summarize the article in 100 words."** Should you say whether you agree with the author?
2. The prompt says: **"Compare online classes and in-person classes."** A student writes three good paragraphs about online classes. What is missing?
3. Which sentence evaluates?
   - A. The article has five paragraphs.
   - B. The article is about sleep.
   - C. The article's evidence is weak because it comes from one person's experience.
4. Find the two task verbs: **"Describe one problem in your community and argue for a solution."** What does each verb ask you to do?
5. Correct this sentence: **"Online classes are more easier then in-person classes."**

Suggested answers

1. **No.**
   Summarize is a Group 1 verb. Report the author's main ideas. Your opinion is not part of the task.
2. **The in-person classes, and the comparison.**
   Compare needs two things and the connections between them. Writing about one thing is describing, not comparing.
3. **C.**
   It gives a judgment (weak) and a reason (because). A and B report facts.
4. **Describe and argue.**
   First, say what the problem is like, with details. Then take a position on a solution and support it with reasons. The answer needs both parts.
5. **Online classes are easier than in-person classes.**
   Easy is a short adjective, so it becomes easier, without more. The comparing word is than.

Next step

Try this with a prompt from one of your classes

1. Find every task verb. Some prompts have two or three.
2. Decide which group each verb belongs to.
3. For each verb, write one sentence that begins "I need to _____."
4. If a verb is not on this page, or you are not sure what it means in your course, ask your instructor.

Related pages

[Understanding a writing prompt]

How to find the task, the requirements, and the limits in any prompt.

Reading a rubric

How to see what your instructor will look for in your answer.

Quote, paraphrase, or summarize Coming soon

Three ways to bring a source into your writing.

FOR INSTRUCTORS **Writing a clear assignment prompt**

Includes defining the task verb as you use it in your course.

UNDERSTAND THE ASSIGNMENT

Reading a Rubric

Use this page when your instructor gives you a rubric, and you want to know how your work will be graded.

Online: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/assignments/rubric.html

What a rubric is

A **rubric** is a chart that shows how your work will be graded. It tells you what your instructor will look for and how much each part counts. Many students look at the rubric only after they receive a grade. It helps more if you read it before you start.

Most rubrics have three parts:

- **Criteria.** These are the things your instructor grades, such as your argument or your evidence. They are usually the rows.
- **Levels.** These show how well you did, from the highest to the lowest. They are usually the columns.
- **Descriptions.** Each box describes what the work looks like at that level.

Many rubrics also show **points** or a percentage for each criterion. A criterion with more points matters more.

Use a rubric three times

1. **Before you write.** Read the highest level for each criterion. That is your goal.
2. **Before you submit.** Check your draft against each criterion, one at a time.
3. **After you get your grade.** Find the level you received. Compare it with the level above it to see what to change next time.

KEY TERMS

Rubric: a chart that shows how your work will be graded.

Criteria: the things that are graded. This word is plural. One of them is a criterion.

Level: a step on the scale, such as Strong or Developing.

Example: reading a rubric closely

This rubric is for an essay that argues for one change at a workplace, in a neighborhood, or at a college. Each number matches a note below the rubric.

A rubric with notes

Essay 2: A Change Worth Making (100 points)

Criteria 1	Strong 3	Developing	Beginning
Argument **30 points** 2	States one specific change and gives clear reasons the reader would accept.	States a change, but the reasons are general or incomplete.	Describes a problem but does not argue for a change.
Evidence **30 points**	Uses at least two credible sources and explains how each one supports the argument. 4	Uses two sources but does not explain how they support the argument.	Uses fewer than two sources, or the sources are not credible.
Organization **20 points**	Each paragraph has one main idea, and the order is easy to follow.	Most paragraphs have one main idea, but the order is sometimes confusing.	The ideas are hard to follow.
Language **20 points** 5	Sentences are clear. Errors are few and do not affect meaning.	Some errors make the reader slow down, but the meaning is clear.	Errors often make the meaning unclear.

1. **The criteria.**
   This instructor grades four things: argument, evidence, organization, and language. Anything not on this list is not graded.

2. **The points.**
   Argument and evidence are worth 60 of the 100 points. Give most of your time to those two.

3. **The highest level.**
   Read this column first. It describes the essay your instructor hopes to receive, so you can use it as a checklist.

4. **The difference between two levels.**
   Strong and **Developing** both use two sources. The difference is one phrase: the strong essay explains how each source supports the argument.

5. **How language counts.**
   Language is worth 20 points. This rubric looks at meaning: an error matters most when it makes a sentence hard to understand. When you edit, fix those errors first.

Language focus: small words that separate the levels

LANGUAGE FOCUS

Words on a scale

Rubrics often describe every level with the same sentence and change only one or two words. Learn to see those words. Each row below goes from the most to the least.

Scale words, from most to least

What is measured	Level 4 (most)	Level 3	Level 2	Level 1 (least)
How many	all	most	some	few, none
How often	always, consistently	usually, often	sometimes	rarely, never
How completely	fully, thoroughly	mostly	partly	not

The word but

In a rubric, the words after **but** tell you what is missing. Read them as advice.

- **States a change, but the reasons are general.** To improve: make the reasons specific.

WATCH FOR THIS

Few and **a few** are different. **Errors are few** means there are almost none, which is good. **There are a few errors** means there are some.

Sentence starters: asking about a rubric

Fill in each blank with your own words.

BEFORE YOU WRITE

In the rubric, what does "_____" mean?

What is the difference between "_____" and "_____" for _____?

Could you show us an example of work at the highest level?

WHEN THERE IS NO RUBRIC

How will this assignment be graded?

What matters most in this assignment?

AFTER YOU GET YOUR GRADE

I received "_____" for _____. What would make it "_____"?

Practice

Use the example rubric on this page to answer the questions.

1. Which two criteria are worth the most points?
2. A student's essay has almost no grammar errors. It describes a problem at work in detail, but it never argues for a change. Which level will it receive for Argument?

3. A student quotes two credible sources but does not say how they support the argument. Which level is this for Evidence? What one change would raise it?
4. The rubric says **"Errors are few."** Does that mean many errors or not many?
5. You have one hour before the essay is due. Which is the better use of the hour: making your reasons clearer, or checking every comma?

Suggested answers

1. **Argument and Evidence.**
   Each is worth 30 points. Together they are 60 of the 100 points.
2. **Beginning.**
   That box says "Describes a problem but does not argue for a change." Good grammar earns points in the Language row. It cannot replace the argument.
3. **Developing.**
   To reach Strong, the student needs to add a sentence after each source that explains how it supports the argument.
4. **Not many.**
   Few without a means almost none.
5. **Making your reasons clearer.**
   Argument is worth 30 points. In the Language row, an error matters most when it makes the meaning unclear, and a comma rarely does that.

Next step

Try this with a rubric from one of your classes

1. Find the criterion with the most points.
2. Highlight the description at the highest level for each criterion.
3. Turn each description into a question. For example: "Did I explain how each source supports my argument?"

4. Answer those questions before you submit your work.

Related pages

Understanding a writing prompt
The prompt for the essay this rubric grades.

Task verbs: analyze, compare, evaluate
What each common task verb asks you to do.

Understanding instructor feedback Coming soon
How to turn comments on your work into a plan.

FOR INSTRUCTORS **Rubrics and where language accuracy fits**
The Instructor Companion page that pairs with this one.

Take part in class

TAKE PART IN CLASS

Writing a Discussion Post

Use this page when your class has an online discussion and you need to write your first post.

Online: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/participate/discussion-post.html

What a discussion post is

Many college courses have an online **discussion board**. Your instructor asks a question. Each student writes an answer, called a **first post**, and the whole class can read it. Then students reply to each other.

This page is about the first post. A discussion is a conversation in writing. It is more careful than a text message and less formal than an essay.

Where a discussion post fits

What is compared	Text message	Discussion post	Essay
Who reads it	A friend	Your classmates and your instructor	Your instructor, in most classes
Sentences	Short pieces and abbreviations	Complete sentences	Complete sentences in organized paragraphs
Using "I"	Yes	Yes, in most classes	It depends on the assignment
Your opinion	Yes	Yes, with a reason	Yes, with reasons and evidence

What instructors expect

Instructors do not always write these expectations down. In most U.S. college classes, they apply to every student.

- **Answer every part of the question.** Many discussion questions have two parts, such as “which one, and why?”
- **Give your own opinion, and give a reason for it.** Repeating the reading is not enough.
- **Connect your answer to the course.** Use an idea from the reading or the lesson.
- **Remember who can read your post.** Your whole class can read it. Share only what you are comfortable sharing with classmates.
- **Post early when you can.** Classmates need time to read your post and reply.

KEY TERMS

Discussion board: the place in an online course where students post and reply.

First post: your own answer to the instructor’s question. It is also called an initial post.

Reply: a response to a classmate’s post.

Netiquette: polite and respectful behavior in online communication.

Four parts of a strong first post

1. **Answer.** Answer the question in your first sentence. Use some of the words from the question.
2. **Reason.** Say why. One clear reason is better than three weak ones.
3. **Support.** Add an idea from the reading, an example from your experience, or both.
4. **Question.** End with a question for your classmates.

WHY END WITH A QUESTION?

A question is an invitation. Classmates who are looking for a post to reply to will find yours easy to answer, and you will get more interesting replies. Do this unless your prompt asks for something different.

Example: a first post

The instructor asked this question: **"This week's reading describes three time-management strategies. Which strategy would be most useful for you, and why? Write 100–150 words."**

Here is one student's post. Each number matches a note below the post.

A first post with notes

The most useful strategy for me is breaking a large task into small steps. (1) I work full time, so I rarely have three free hours to study. (2) The reading explains that a small step is easier to start than a large task, (3) and I think this is true. For example, last week I had to read a long chapter for my biology class. (4) I divided the chapter into four sections and read one section each night after work. I finished one day early. I am less sure about the weekly schedule, because my work hours change every week. (5) Does anyone else have a schedule that changes? How do you plan your study time? (6)

(1) **The answer.**
The first sentence answers "which strategy." It repeats the words **most useful** and **strategy** from the question, so readers know at once what the post is about.

(2) **The reason.**
This sentence answers "why." It is specific to the writer's own life.

(3) **Support from the reading.**
The writer names the source (**The reading explains that**) and gives the idea in different words.

(4) **Support from experience.**
For example tells readers that a real case is coming. The details (four sections, one each night) make it believable.

5 **A second thought.**
This part is optional. It shows that the writer considered another strategy, and it prepares the question.

6 **The question.**
The question comes from the post, and a classmate can answer it from experience. It cannot be answered with only “yes” or “no.”

Language focus: asking a question

LANGUAGE FOCUS

Word order in questions

In most English questions, a helping verb such as do, does, did, has, or would comes before the subject.

How a question is built

Question word	Helping verb	Subject	Main verb and the rest
How	do	you	plan your study time?
What	would	you	do in this situation?
Why	does	this strategy	work for you?
(none)	Has	anyone else	had this experience?

WATCH FOR THIS

After do, does, or did, the main verb has no ending. Write **Why does this strategy work?** Do not write “Why does this strategy works?”

Closed and open questions

A **closed question** can be answered in one word. An **open question** needs an explanation. Open questions get better replies.

- Closed: **Do you agree?**
- Open: **What is one reason someone might disagree?**

Open questions often begin with how, why, or what.

Sentence starters

Fill in each blank with your own words.

TO ANSWER THE QUESTION

The most _____ for me is _____.

I think _____ because _____.

TO USE THE READING

The reading explains that _____.

According to the article, _____.

TO GIVE AN EXAMPLE

For example, _____.

In my experience, _____.

TO END WITH A QUESTION

Has anyone else had this experience with _____?

How would you handle _____?

What is one reason someone might disagree with _____?

Practice

1. A student posts: **“I think the weekly schedule is the best strategy. Do you agree?”** Which two of the four parts are missing?
2. Which closing question will get the most useful replies?
   - A. Do you agree?
   - B. Thoughts?
   - C. What do you do when two assignments are due on the same day?
3. Correct this question: **“Why this strategy works for you?”**
4. Correct this question: **“Anyone has tried this strategy?”**

Suggested answers

1. **The reason and the support.**
   The post gives an answer and a question. It does not say why, and it has no example or idea from the reading.
2. **C.**
   A classmate can answer it from experience, and the answer needs more than one word. A is a closed question. B is not a complete question, so readers do not know what you are asking.
3. **Why does this strategy work for you?**
   The helping verb does comes before the subject. After does, the main verb has no ending: work.
4. **Has anyone tried this strategy?**
   The helping verb has moves to the front of the question.

Next step

Check your post before you submit it

1. Did I answer every part of the question?
2. Did I give a reason?
3. Did I add an example or an idea from the reading?
4. Did I end with an open question?
5. Is my post the right length? Check the word count in the prompt.

Related pages

Understanding a writing prompt
How to find the task, the requirements, and the limits in any prompt, including a discussion question.

Replying to classmates
How to agree, add an idea, and disagree politely.

Writing a journal or reflection Coming soon
How to write about your own learning.

FOR INSTRUCTORS **Setting expectations for discussions and journals**
The Instructor Companion page that pairs with this one.

TAKE PART IN CLASS

Replying to Classmates

Use this page when you need to reply to a classmate's post in an online discussion.

Online: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/participate/replying.html

What a good reply does

A **reply** is your response to a classmate's post. A good reply adds something to the conversation. "I agree" or "Good post" is friendly, but it gives your classmate nothing to think about, and most instructors do not count it.

There are four useful kinds of reply. One reply can do more than one of them.

1. **Answer.** If your classmate asked a question, answer it. This is the easiest way to start.
2. **Agree and add.** Say what you agree with, then add something new: an example, a reason, or an idea from the reading.
3. **Disagree politely.** Give a different view, and give your reason.
4. **Ask.** Ask about something you want to understand better.

What instructors expect

Instructors do not always write these expectations down. In most U.S. college classes, they apply to every student.

- **Use your classmate's name.** It shows who you are talking to, and it is polite.
- **Show that you read the post.** Name the idea you are responding to.
- **You may disagree.** Disagreement is a normal part of a college discussion. It is welcome when you give a reason.
- **Write about the idea, not the person.**

- **Check the prompt.** It tells you how many replies to write and how long each one should be.

A KIND CHOICE

If you can choose, reply to a post that has no replies yet. Every student hopes that someone will answer.

KEY TERMS

Reply: a response to a classmate's post.

Thread: one post and all the replies to it.

Tone: the feeling your words give the reader, such as friendly, angry, or respectful.

Example: a reply

A classmate named Daniela wrote that breaking a large task into small steps works for her, but a weekly schedule does not, because her work hours change. She ended her post with a question: **"Does anyone else have a schedule that changes? How do you plan your study time?"**

Here is one reply. Each number matches a note below it.

A reply with notes

Daniela, (1) my schedule changes every week too, so I understand the problem. (2) I like your idea of reading one section each night. What works for me is planning on Sunday night, after my manager posts the schedule. I look for three short blocks of 30 minutes and put them in my phone calendar. (3) I see the weekly schedule a little differently, though. I think it can still work if you make a new one each week. (4) Have you tried studying during your breaks at work? (5)

(1) **The name.**
The reply begins with the classmate's name.

(2) **The connection.**
This sentence shows that the writer read the post and understood it.

3 **The answer.**
Daniela asked how other students plan their study time. The writer answers with exact details: when, how many, how long.

4 **A polite disagreement.**
The writer has a different view of the weekly schedule. The words **a little differently** and **I think** make the tone friendly. The second sentence gives the reason.

5 **A question back.**
The question keeps the conversation going. This part is optional.

Language focus: disagreeing politely

LANGUAGE FOCUS

Softening words

In English, a very direct disagreement can sound rude, even when the writer does not mean it that way. Writers add small **softening words** to keep a friendly tone.

The same opinion, with a different tone

Too direct	Polite and clear
You are wrong.	I see this differently.
That is not true.	I am not sure that is always true.
This strategy does not work.	This strategy might not work for everyone.
Your post is confusing.	I did not understand your second point. Could you explain it?

Common softening words: **I think, in my experience, might, may, could, sometimes, not always, a little**.

A pattern you can use

Say what you agree with or understand. Then give your different view and your reason.

- **I agree that small steps help, but I think a schedule is also important because it protects your study time.**
- **I understand your point about cost. In my experience, though, the free tools work well.**

WATCH FOR THIS

Softening changes your tone. It does not change your opinion. A reply with too many softening words can hide what you think, so state your view and give your reason.

Sentence starters

Fill in each blank with your own words.

TO ANSWER A CLASSMATE'S QUESTION

You asked about _____. What works for me is _____.

TO AGREE AND ADD

I agree that _____, and I would add _____.

I had a similar experience when _____.

TO DISAGREE POLITELY

I see this differently because _____.

I understand your point about _____, but _____.

TO ASK

Could you say more about _____?

What did you mean by _____?

Practice

1. The prompt says a reply "must add something." Which reply does?
   - A. Great post! I agree with everything you said.

- B. I agree that small steps help. I use the same idea for math homework: I do five problems, and then I take a break.
- C. Nice job.

2. A classmate's post ends with this question: **"How do you stay focused when you study at home?"** What is the easiest way to begin your reply?
3. Make this sentence polite and clear: **"You are wrong about the weekly schedule."**
4. Which sentence is about the idea, not the person?
   - A. You did not read the article carefully.
   - B. I think the article says something different in the second paragraph.

Suggested answers

1. **B.**
   It says what the writer agrees with and adds a new example. A and C are friendly, but they add nothing.
2. **Answer the question.**
   For example: "You asked how to stay focused at home. What works for me is putting my phone in another room."
3. **One possible answer: "I see the weekly schedule differently. I think it helps because it shows me when I am free."**
   The new sentence talks about the schedule, not the classmate, and it gives a reason. Other answers are possible.
4. **B.**
   Sentence A judges the classmate. Sentence B talks about the article and gives the classmate something to check.

Next step

Check your reply before you submit it

1. Did I use my classmate's name?

2. Did I show which idea I am responding to?
3. Did I add something: an answer, an example, a reason, or a different view?
4. If I disagreed, did I give a reason and write about the idea?
5. Is my reply the right length? Check the prompt.

Related pages

Writing a discussion post
How to write the first post, including a closing question.

Interacting in class: common expectations Coming soon
What instructors and classmates usually expect in a U.S. college class.

FOR INSTRUCTORS **Setting expectations for discussions and journals**
The Instructor Companion page that pairs with this one.

Grammar for college writing

GRAMMAR FOR COLLEGE WRITING

Articles: A, An, The

Use this page when you are not sure whether a noun needs a, an, the, or no article.

Online: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/grammar/articles.html

What articles do

English has three **articles**: **a**, **an**, and **the**. An article comes before a noun. It tells your reader whether you mean one specific thing or any one of many.

- **I read an article about sleep.** The reader does not know which article. It is one of many.
- **I read the article about sleep.** The reader knows which article. Maybe the instructor assigned it.

Many languages have no articles, so this part of English takes practice. A missing article rarely stops a reader from understanding you. Still, articles appear in almost every sentence, so a small improvement shows everywhere in your writing.

KEY TERMS

Noun: a word for a person, place, thing, or idea.

Countable noun: a noun you can count. It has a plural form: one essay, two essays.

Uncountable noun: a noun you cannot count. It has no plural form: research, information.

Three questions for every noun

When you are not sure, ask these questions in order. Stop at the first “yes.”

1. **Does my reader know exactly which one I mean?** If yes, use **the**.
2. **Is the noun singular and countable?** If yes, use **a** or **an**.

3 **Is the noun plural or uncountable, and am I speaking in general?** If yes, use no article.

When does my reader know which one?

- **You already mentioned it. I wrote a draft. The draft was too short.**
- **Your sentence identifies it. the article that we read this week**, **the first paragraph**
- **There is only one. the author** of an article, **the instructor** of your class, **the sun**

A or an?

Listen to the first sound of the next word. The spelling does not decide.

- Use **a** before a consonant sound: **a draft, a university, a one-page summary**.
- Use **an** before a vowel sound: **an essay, an hour, an MLA citation**.

Example: articles in a paragraph

This paragraph comes from a student's summary. Each number matches a note below it.

A paragraph with notes

I read an article 1 about sleep for my psychology class. The article 2 explains that college students need at least seven hours of sleep. Research 3 shows that students 4 who sleep less have more trouble remembering information. The author 5 gives an example from a study at a large university. 6 In the study, 7 students who slept longer earned higher grades.

1 **First mention.**
The reader does not know which article yet. The noun is singular and countable, so it needs **a** or **an**. **Article** begins with a vowel sound, so the writer uses **an**.

2 **Second mention.**
Now the reader knows which article, so the writer uses **the**.

3 **An uncountable noun, in general.**
Research is uncountable. The writer means research in general, so there is no article. **Information**, later in the same sentence, works the same way.

4 **A plural noun, in general.**
The writer means students in general, not one specific group, so there is no article.

5 **Only one.**
The article has one author, so the reader knows which person the writer means.

6 **Two first mentions.**
The reader does not know which study or which university. **University** begins with a "y" sound, so the writer uses **a**, not **an**.

7 **Second mention.**
The study was introduced in the sentence before, so now it is **the study**.

Three common problems

WATCH FOR THESE

1. Uncountable nouns in college writing

These nouns are common in college, and all of them are uncountable in English: **research, evidence, information, advice, feedback, homework, equipment, software**. Do not use a or an with them, and do not add -s.

Uncountable nouns

Not this	Write this
I did a research.	I did research. / I read a study.
The essay needs more evidences.	The essay needs more evidence.
She gave me an advice.	She gave me some advice. / She gave me a piece of advice.

Not this	Write this
I found many informations.	I found a lot of information.
I finished my homeworks.	I finished my homework. / I finished my assignments.

2. A singular countable noun with nothing before it

A singular countable noun cannot stand alone. It needs an article or another small word such as my, this, or one. Use only one of them.

Singular countable nouns

Not this	Write this
I wrote essay about my job.	I wrote an essay about my job.
The my essay is finished.	My essay is finished.

3. The in general statements

When you speak about a whole group in general, use a plural noun with no article.

- General: **Students need feedback.** This means students everywhere.
- Specific: **The students in my group need feedback.** This means one group that the reader can identify.

Phrases you will use often

You can learn these phrases as whole pieces. The article is already correct.

TO WRITE ABOUT A READING

According to the author, _____.

The main idea of the article is _____.

In the first paragraph, _____.

TO GIVE SUPPORT

This is an example of _____.

A study by _____ shows that _____.

TO EXPLAIN YOUR OWN WRITING

The purpose of this essay is to _____.

As a result, _____.

Practice

Choose **a**, **an**, **the**, or no article for each blank.

1. I wrote _____ essay about my first job.
2. _____ essay that I wrote last week needs more support.
3. My instructor gave me _____ feedback on my draft.
4. She said that I need _____ stronger thesis.
5. I need to find _____ information about wages.
6. It took me _____ hour to revise one paragraph.
7. _____ students often work while they attend college.

Then correct this sentence: **“I did a research for my homeworks.”**

Suggested answers

1. **an**
   First mention, singular and countable. Essay begins with a vowel sound.
2. **The**
   The words that I wrote last week identify which essay.
3. **No article**
   Feedback is uncountable. Some feedback is also correct.
4. **a**
   Singular and countable, and the reader does not know which thesis yet. Stronger begins with a consonant sound.

5. **No article**
   Information is uncountable. Some information is also correct.
6. **an**
   The h in hour is silent, so the word begins with a vowel sound.
7. **No article**
   The sentence is about students in general. The first word is Students, with a capital letter.

Corrected sentence: I did research for my homework.

Both nouns are uncountable, so they take no a and no -s.

Next step

Try this with your own writing

1. Choose one paragraph from a draft.
2. Circle every noun.
3. Ask the three questions for each noun.
4. Check the list of uncountable nouns on this page.

More practice

The Purdue Online Writing Lab (OWL) is a writing site from Purdue University. Many college classes use it.

Purdue OWL: article exercises **(https://owl.purdue.edu/owl_exercises/grammar_exercises/articles/)**
Three exercises with answer pages.

Purdue OWL: How to Use Articles
(https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_writing/grammar/using_articles.html)
A longer explanation, with rules for names of places.

Related pages

Subject-verb agreement Coming soon

How to make the verb match its subject.

Building a paragraph Coming soon

How to organize one main idea with support.

Ask for help

ASK FOR HELP

Working with a Tutor

Use this page when you are thinking about getting help from a tutor, or you are getting ready for your first session.

Online: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/help/working-with-a-tutor.html

What a tutor does

A **tutor** is a person who helps you with your coursework outside of class. A tutor can explain an idea again, work through a problem with you, look at your writing with you, and help you plan how to study.

A tutor helps you do your own work. A tutor does not do the work for you, and does not give you a grade.

What to know before you go

Nobody always says these things out loud. In U.S. colleges, they are true for every student.

- **Going to a tutor is normal.** It does not mean you are failing. Many students with high grades use tutoring often.
- **Instructors see it as a good sign.** It shows that you take responsibility for your learning.
- **You do not need a big problem.** One question is enough.
- **Earlier is better.** A tutor can help you more a week before the due date than an hour before it.

AT OCTC

Tutoring in the Teaching and Learning Center (TLC) is free for OCTC students. The TLC asks students to make an appointment for help with writing. For this term's hours and the TLC's phone number and email, see This semester.

KEY TERMS

Tutor: a person who helps you with coursework outside of class.

Peer tutor: a student who is trained to tutor other students.

Session: one meeting with a tutor.

Appointment: a time that you reserve before you come.

Walk-in: help that you can get without an appointment.

When to go

Go to a tutor when one of these is true:

- You do not understand part of a lecture or a reading.
- You are falling behind in a class.
- Your test grades are lower than you want.
- You want help preparing for a test.
- You are stuck on a homework assignment.
- You do not know how to start a paper or make an outline.
- You are not sure how to do research or use sources.
- You need help using a computer or a program for class.
- You want help organizing your time and your materials.

Example: starting a session

The first minute of a session matters. If you say clearly what you need, the tutor can start helping at once. Here is what one student says. Each number matches a note below.

What a student says, with notes
Hi, my name is Ana. I have an appointment at 10:00 for help with writing. (1)
I am in English 101 with Professor Lee. (2)

I am writing an essay that argues for a change at my workplace. Here is the prompt, and here is my draft. 3

My instructor said that my reasons are too general. Could we look at my second paragraph? 4

At the end of the session

So my next step is to add an example to each reason. Is that right? 5

1. **Who you are and why you came.**
   Ana gives her name, her appointment time, and the kind of help she wants.
2. **Your class and your instructor.**
   The tutor needs these to understand the assignment. Tutors also write them on a form for the tutoring center.
3. **The assignment itself.**
   Ana brings the prompt and her draft. The tutor can read exactly what the instructor asked for.
4. **One specific request.**
   Ana does not say “Is this good?” She names one problem and one place to look. **Could we** makes the request polite.
5. **A check before leaving.**
   Ana says her next step in her own words and asks whether it is correct. Now she knows what to do after the session.

Language focus: asking for exactly what you need

LANGUAGE FOCUS

From general to specific

A specific question gets a more useful answer. Say what you already understand, and then say where you get lost.

Making a request more useful

Too general	More useful
I don't understand anything.	I understand the first step, but I get lost at the second one.
Is my paper good?	Does my first paragraph answer the prompt?
Can you fix my grammar?	Could you show me one kind of error that I make often?

Polite requests

These three forms are polite and common. The first two are followed by the simple form of the verb. After Would you mind, the verb ends in -ing.

- **Could you explain that another way?**
- **Could we look at my second paragraph?**
- **Would you mind explaining that again?**

WATCH FOR THIS

A tutor may ask, **"Do you mind if I write on your draft?"** If it is fine with you, the answer is **"No, I don't mind"** or **"No, go ahead."** Here, no means "it is not a problem."

Sentence starters

Fill in each blank with your own words.

TO MAKE AN APPOINTMENT

I would like to make an appointment for help with _____.

I am free on _____. Is there a time then?

TO BEGIN A SESSION

I am working on _____ for _____, and I am stuck on _____.

WHEN YOU DO NOT UNDERSTAND

Could you explain that another way?

Could you show me an example?

Could you say that more slowly, please?

TO CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

So I should _____. Is that right?

TO END A SESSION

Thank you. This helped me with _____.

May I come back after I revise?

Practice

1. Which two are good reasons to see a tutor?
   - A. I got a low grade on my first test.
   - B. I want someone to write my conclusion.
   - C. I do not know how to start my outline.
2. Make this request more useful: **"I don't understand anything about this assignment."**
3. A tutor asks: **"Do you mind if I write on your draft?"** It is fine with you. What do you say?
4. Your paper is due in eight days. When is the best time to see a tutor: this week, or the night before the paper is due?
5. Name three things to bring to a session about a writing assignment.

Suggested answers

1. **A and C.**
   A tutor can help you prepare for the next test and plan your outline. B asks the tutor to do your work, and a tutor will not do that.
2. **One possible answer: "I understand the topic, but I am not sure what 'analyze' means in the prompt."**
   Say what you understand, and then name the part that is unclear. Other answers are possible.

3. **“No, I don’t mind.” or “No, go ahead.”**
   After Do you mind, the word no means that it is not a problem.
4. **This week.**
   You will have time to use what you learn. You may also need an appointment, and times fill up.
5. **The prompt, your draft, and your class notes.**
   Your syllabus, your textbook, and any handouts also help. Know your instructor’s name and the name of your class.

Next step

Get ready for your first session

1. Check the hours for this term on This semester.
2. Make an appointment if you need one.
3. Gather your prompt, your draft or notes, your syllabus, and your textbook.
4. Write down one specific question to begin with.

Related pages

This semester
Who is in the Teaching and Learning Center this term, and when.

Understanding a writing prompt
Read the prompt closely before your session, and bring your questions.

Emailing an instructor and asking questions Coming soon
How to ask for help in writing.

Help-Seeking as a Strength

(https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/FYE100-pathfinder-guidebook/chapters/ch02/2-3.html)

A lesson from the FYE 100 Pathfinder Guidebook about asking for help.

Instructor Companion

For faculty and staff. Students are welcome to read it too.

INSTRUCTOR COMPANION

Writing a Clear Assignment Prompt

Use this page when you are writing or revising the instructions for a writing assignment.

Online: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/instructors/assignment-prompts.html

What students experience

A prompt is a reading task before it is a writing task. Students who read English as an additional language often read a prompt closely and take its wording literally. That works well when the prompt states its expectations. It works against them when the expectations are implied.

Five features of a prompt cause most of the difficulty:

- **The task is hard to find.** It sits inside background information or a series of questions, and the student cannot tell which questions must be answered.
- **Requirements sound optional.** “You might want to include a few sources” reads as a suggestion.
- **Idioms and cultural references carry the meaning.** “Dig into something that bugs you” depends on phrases a dictionary will not explain.
- **Key terms have no definition.** “Analyze,” “respond critically,” and “polished” mean different things in different courses.
- **The grading criteria are unstated.** Students cannot tell how much weight grammar carries next to ideas and organization.

None of these is a question of ability, and none is limited to multilingual learners. The CCCC statement on multilingual writers puts the principle in one sentence: “Instructors should provide clearly written assignments so that expectations are not left tacit.”

The evidence for stating expectations openly reaches beyond language. In a study at seven minority-serving institutions, two of them community colleges, faculty revised two take-home assignments to state the purpose, the task, and the criteria. Of the 1,800 students invited, 1,174 completed an end-of-term survey. Students who experienced more transparency reported greater academic confidence,

a stronger sense of belonging, and greater mastery of the skills employers value. The benefits were larger for first-generation, low-income, and underrepresented students (Winkelmes et al., 2016). The study did not examine multilingual learners as a separate group.

Six practices

1

State the purpose

In one or two sentences, say what skill the assignment builds and where students will use it again. Purpose helps students decide what matters most in their response.

2

Put the task first and name it with one verb

Lead with the sentence that says what to produce. Then define the task verb as you use it: “In this course, *analyze* means to explain how the parts of the text work together.”

3

Separate what is required from what is optional

Use *must* for requirements. Put suggestions under their own heading. Students are taught that *should* and *may* signal different levels of obligation, so use them consistently.

4

Put the requirements in a list

List length, sources, format, and submission steps as separate items, each with a number where one applies. Give length in words. A page count changes with font and spacing.

5

Explain or remove idioms and cultural references

Replace idioms with literal wording. Offer topic choices that do not depend on cultural or historical knowledge the course has not taught, as the CCCC statement recommends.

6

Say how the work will be evaluated, including language

Share the rubric with the prompt. State how much sentence-level accuracy counts next to ideas, evidence, and organization. State the AI use label for the assignment, using the label from OCTC's AI Label Maker (https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/ai-literacy-playbook/ai-label/). Then say whether a dictionary, a translation tool, and a grammar checker are allowed, because an AI use label does not answer that.

Before and after

Both versions describe the same assignment. The second is the one students see on the paired student page.

BEFORE

For this next paper I'd like you to dig into something that bugs you. We've all been there: something at work or around town that just doesn't work the way it should. What's going on? Why does it matter? Who's affected? What could be done about it?

You'll probably want to bring in a couple of sources to back yourself up, and it should run about three to four pages. Make sure it's polished!

AFTER

PURPOSE

This essay gives you practice building an argument for a specific reader. You will use this skill in other courses and at work.

TASK

Write an essay that argues for one specific change that would improve a problem at your workplace, in your neighborhood, or at this college. In this course, *argue* means to state a position and support it with reasons and evidence.

READER

Write for the people who could make the change.

REQUIREMENTS

- 750–1,000 words
- Evidence from at least two credible sources
- MLA format
- Submitted in Blackboard by the due date listed there

OPTIONAL

You may write in first person (I, my).

GRADING

See the rubric attached to this assignment.

What changed

- **Four idioms are gone:** “dig into,” “bugs you,” “we’ve all been there,” and “back yourself up.”
- **Four questions became one task.** A student no longer has to guess whether each question needs its own answer.
- **“Probably want to” and “a couple” became “at least two.”** The requirement is now a requirement, with a number.
- **Pages became words.**
- **“Polished” became a rubric.**
- **The reader is named.** The first version never says who the essay is for.

Wording you can copy

Replace the text in brackets.

> **Purpose.** This assignment gives you practice with [skill]. You will use this skill when you [situation].
>
> **Task.** Write a [type of text] that [task verb] [topic]. In this course, “[task verb]” means [definition].

Requirements. Your [type of text] must: [list, one item per line].

Optional. You may also [choice].

Language. Most of your grade is for [priorities, such as your argument and evidence]. Grammar and word choice count for [amount, or "only where they make your meaning unclear"].

Tools. AI use label: [No AI / AI-supported / AI-integrated]. [If AI-supported: You may use AI for (uses). You may not use AI to (limit).] [If AI-integrated: With AI, you will (steps). On your own, you must (your part). To show how you used AI, turn in (evidence).] You [may / may not] use [a dictionary, a translation tool, a grammar checker] to [purpose]. If you are not sure whether a tool is allowed, ask me before you use it.

Questions. If any part of this prompt is unclear, ask me. Questions about a prompt are welcome.

Check before you post

These are the five questions the student page teaches. A student should be able to answer each one from the prompt alone.

1. What do I do? (One task, named with a defined verb.)
2. What do I write about? (The topic and its limits.)
3. Who is my reader?
4. What are the requirements? (Each one stated as a requirement, with a number.)
5. How do I finish? (Where to find the due date, where to submit, and how the work is graded.)

For a stronger check, ask a colleague outside your discipline to read the prompt and tell you what it asks for.

Link for students

The paired student page teaches the five questions, the difference between *must*, *should*, and *may*, and ways to ask about a prompt. You can add this line to an assignment in Blackboard:

> Before you start, read Understanding a Writing Prompt. It shows you how to find the task, the requirements, and the limits in any prompt.

Tool

The Assignment prompt builder turns these practices into a fill-in form, and it includes a Copilot prompt for checking a prompt you already have.

Sources

- Conference on College Composition and Communication. (2020). *CCCC statement on second language writing and multilingual writers* (https://cccc.ncte.org/cccc/resources/positions/secondlangwriting). See "Writing Assignment Design" and "Assessment."
- Winkelmes, M., Bernacki, M., Butler, J., Zochowski, M., Golanics, J., & Weavil, K. H. (2016). A teaching intervention that increases underserved college students' success. *Peer Review*, *18*(1/2), 31–36. A summary handout with example assignments: Transparent Instruction and Its Impact on Learning (PDF) (https://ts3.nashonline.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Winkelmes-TILT-Handout-accessible.pdf). More on the framework: Transparency in Learning and Teaching (TILT Higher Ed) (https://tilthighered.com/).

INSTRUCTOR COMPANION

Setting Expectations for Discussions and Journals

Use this page when you assign discussion posts, journals, or reflections.

Online: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/instructors/discussions-journals.html

What students experience

Discussions and journals depend on unwritten rules more than any other assignment type. An instructor who has read thousands of posts knows what a good one looks like, so a prompt such as "post your thoughts and respond to two classmates" feels complete. To a student, it leaves most of the assignment undefined.

This affects every student. Some skim the instructions and miss a detail that is there. Others read every word and still cannot find the expectation, because it was never written down. Multilingual learners are often in the second group, and they may also be working from classroom conventions learned in a different educational system.

These are the questions students most often cannot answer from the prompt:

DISCUSSIONS

- How formal should my writing be?
- May I write "I"?
- Do I need sources?
- What counts as a reply?
- May I disagree with a classmate? With the reading? With the instructor?
- Is my grammar graded?

JOURNALS AND REFLECTIONS

- Who will read this?
- How personal should it be?
- May I say that something in the course is not working for me?
- Is it safe to admit that I did not understand?
- Is my grammar graded?

Expectations about disagreement, self-disclosure, and how to address an instructor differ between educational systems. The CCCC statement asks instructors to check their assignments for unstated cultural assumptions, and it notes that topics drawing on personal experience can be sensitive for some students. The practical response is the same in every case: state the expectation.

Eight practices

1

Say what the activity is for

One sentence is enough. “This discussion gives you practice explaining an idea from the reading to other people.”

2

Say who will read it

Students write differently for the whole class than for one instructor. For a journal, say plainly whether anyone but you will see it.

3

Describe the style you expect

State whether you want complete sentences, whether “I” is acceptable, and whether sources are needed. “Be professional” and “use netiquette” do not answer these questions.

4

Define a reply

Give a length and say what a reply must do: answer a classmate’s question, add an example, or explain a different view with a reason. Say that “I agree” alone does not count.

5

Say that disagreement is welcome, and show how

A student who was taught not to contradict a classmate or an instructor may need explicit permission. Give them wording: “I see this differently because …”

6

Say how language is graded

Decide how much sentence-level accuracy counts in low-stakes writing, and state it either way. A student who does not know may assume that every error costs points, and write less.

7

Show an annotated model

One model post with notes shows length, style, and depth faster than a paragraph of description. The transparency framework treats annotated examples as part of the criteria (Winkelmes et al., 2016).

8

Offer an alternative to personal topics

When a prompt asks about family, background, or personal difficulty, give a second option that does not, as the CCCC statement recommends.

A PRACTICE TO TRY

Ask students to end each first post with an open question for classmates. It gives every student who must “reply to two classmates” a place to start. This is practitioner advice. We did not find a study that tests it directly.

Before and after

Both versions describe the same discussion. The second matches the example on the paired student page.

BEFORE

AFTER

PURPOSE

Post your thoughts on this week's reading and respond to two classmates. Be thoughtful, and remember your netiquette!

This discussion gives you practice explaining an idea from the reading to other people.

FIRST POST

Answer this question: Which time-management strategy from the reading would be most useful for you, and why? Write 100–150 words. Give one reason and one example. End with a question for your classmates.

REPLIES

Reply to two classmates. Each reply must be at least 50 words. A reply must add something: answer your classmate's question, give an example, or explain a different view with a reason.

STYLE

Write in complete sentences. You may use "I." You do not need outside sources.

DISAGREEMENT

You may disagree with a classmate or with the reading. Give a reason, and write about the idea, not the person.

GRADING

See the rubric. Grammar and spelling are not graded in discussions unless they make your meaning unclear.

DUE DATES

See Blackboard for the first-post and reply due dates.

What changed

- **"Your thoughts" became one question with two parts.**
- **"Thoughtful" became a length, a reason, and an example.**

- **“Respond” became a definition of a reply.**
- **“Netiquette” became two concrete expectations:** a style, and a way to disagree.
- **The grading of language is stated.** The line shown is one possible policy. Use your own.

Wording you can copy

Replace the text in brackets.

For journals and reflections

> **Reader.** [Only I will read your journal. / Your journal is shared with your group.]
>
> **What to share.** You choose what to share. You never have to write about private matters. If a prompt asks about personal experience and you prefer not to answer, you may write about [alternative topic].
>
> **Honesty.** You may write about what is difficult or not working for you in this course. Honest answers will not lower your grade.
>
> **Language.** I read your journal for your ideas. [Grammar and spelling are not graded. / Grammar and spelling count for (amount).]

For discussions, in place of “netiquette”

> In our discussions:
>
> - Begin a reply with your classmate’s name.
> - Write in complete sentences. Do not write in all capital letters.
> - You may disagree. Give a reason, and write about the idea, not the person.
> - Jokes and sarcasm are easy to misread in writing. Use them with care.
> - If a post confuses or upsets you, ask the writer a question before you respond, or contact me.

Links for students

Two student pages pair with this one. The first teaches the four parts of a first post and how to form an open question. The second teaches four kinds of reply and how to disagree politely. You can add these lines to a discussion in Blackboard:

> Before you post, read Writing a Discussion Post. It shows you what a strong first post includes.
>
> Before you reply, read Replying to Classmates. It shows you how to add to a conversation and how to disagree politely.

To draft or check a prompt of your own, use the Assignment prompt builder.

Sources

- Conference on College Composition and Communication. (2020). *CCCC statement on second language writing and multilingual writers* (https://cccc.ncte.org/cccc/resources/positions/secondlangwriting). See "Writing Assignment Design" and Part Four, "Guidelines for Teacher Preparation."
- Winkelmes, M., Bernacki, M., Butler, J., Zochowski, M., Golanics, J., & Weavil, K. H. (2016). A teaching intervention that increases underserved college students' success. *Peer Review, 18*(1/2), 31–36.

INSTRUCTOR COMPANION

Assignment Prompt Builder

Use this page when you want to draft a new assignment prompt or check one you already have.

Online: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/instructors/prompt-builder.html

Build a prompt

Fill in what you know, then choose **Build prompt**. The tool assembles your answers under clear headings and lists anything a student could not tell from the prompt. Copy the result into Blackboard and edit it there.

The fill-in builder works on the website. Open this page online to use it: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/instructors/prompt-builder.html

Check a prompt with Copilot

If you already have a prompt, Microsoft Copilot can read it the way a careful student would and show you what is missing. Copilot is part of the college's Microsoft 365 package. Copy the text below into Copilot, then paste your own prompt at the end.

You are helping a college instructor revise an assignment prompt so that every student can understand it, including students who read English as an additional language. Do not change what the assignment asks students to do. Do not make the assignment easier.

Step 1. List what a student could not tell from this prompt. Check each of these:
- the task and its main verb
- the topic and its limits
- the intended reader
- each requirement, and its number
- what is optional
- how the work is graded, including how much grammar counts

- the AI use label (No AI, AI-supported, or AI-integrated)
- if the level is AI-supported, exactly which uses are allowed and which are not
- if the level is AI-integrated, the tool, the steps for using AI, what students must do themselves, and what they turn in to show how they used AI
- which language tools are allowed (dictionary, translation tool, grammar checker)
- where to submit the work and where to find the due date

Step 2. List every idiom, cultural reference, and undefined academic term in the prompt. Suggest plain wording for each one.

Step 3. List any requirement that is worded as a suggestion, such as "you might want to."

Step 4. Rewrite the prompt under these headings: Purpose, Task, Reader, Requirements, Optional, Grading, Tools. Use short sentences and common words. Use "must" for requirements. Where information is missing, write [INSTRUCTOR: add ...]. Do not invent requirements, numbers, or policies.

Here is my prompt:
[paste your prompt here]

Or start from scratch with Copilot

If you do not have a prompt yet and prefer a conversation to a form, use this version. Copilot asks you one question at a time and writes the prompt when you say “ready.” Allow five to ten minutes.

You are helping a college instructor write a clear assignment prompt that every student can understand, including students who read English as an additional language.

Interview me one question at a time. Wait for my answer before you ask the next question. Do not draft anything until I say "ready."

Ask about each of these, in this order:
1. the skill this assignment builds, and where students will use it again

2. the type of text and the task, named with one verb
3. what that verb means in my course
4. the topic and its limits
5. the intended reader
6. each requirement, with a number (length in words, number of sources, format)
7. what is optional
8. what counts most in the grade, and how much grammar and word choice count
9. the AI use label (No AI, AI-supported, or AI-integrated). If I answer AI-supported, ask which uses are allowed (for example, brainstorming or feedback on a draft) and which are not. If I answer AI-integrated, ask which tool students use, what they do with AI, what they must do themselves, and what they turn in to show how they used AI
10. which language tools are allowed (dictionary, translation tool, grammar checker)
11. where students submit the work and find the due date

If my answer is vague, ask one follow-up question. If I say "skip," move on.

When I say "ready," write the prompt under these headings: Purpose, Task, Reader, Requirements, Optional, Grading, Tools, Submitting. Use short sentences and common words. Do not use idioms. Use "must" for requirements. For anything I skipped, write [INSTRUCTOR: add ...]. Do not invent requirements, numbers, or college policies.

Start with question 1.

Before you use either prompt

- **Sign in to Copilot with your college account.** For the college's approach to AI in courses, see the AI Literacy Faculty Playbook (https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/ai-literacy-playbook/).
- **Share only the assignment.** Leave out student names and student work.
- **Read the result against your original.** Copilot can change your meaning while it simplifies your wording. The bracketed notes mark places where it needed information from you.
- **You make the decisions.** The tool finds gaps. What the assignment requires is up to you.

Related pages

Writing a clear assignment prompt
The six practices behind this tool, with a before-and-after example.

Setting expectations for discussions and journals
What to add when the assignment is a discussion or a journal.

FOR STUDENTS **Understanding a writing prompt**
The student page that teaches how to read the prompt you write.

INSTRUCTOR COMPANION

Rubrics and Where Language Accuracy Fits

Use this page when you are building or revising a rubric, or deciding how much grammar should count.

Online: https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/language-of-college/instructors/rubrics-language.html

What students experience

A rubric is one of the hardest texts in a course to read. It is dense, its levels differ by a single adverb, and its vocabulary ("sophisticated," "adequate," "demonstrates command") describes a judgment without saying what to do. Students reading in an additional language meet all of that at once.

The language row causes three specific problems:

- **The top level is out of reach.** A description such as "free of grammatical errors" tells a writer who is still learning English that the highest level is closed, whatever the quality of the thinking.
- **Language is graded twice.** Sentence-level errors lower the reader's impression of the whole paper, and the scores for ideas and organization fall with it.
- **Language is graded in secret.** The rubric has no language row, but points come off for grammar anyway. Students cannot plan for a criterion they cannot see.

The CCCC statement on multilingual writers addresses the second problem directly. It asks instructors to weigh several features of a text, including topic development, organization, grammar, and word choice, "rather than focus only on one or two of these features that stand out as problematic." The same statement describes learning academic literacy in an additional language as "a complex, recursive, lifelong process." One semester will not finish it, and a rubric should not assume that it will.

Decide first: is accuracy an outcome of this assignment?

How much language should count depends on what the assignment is for. Answer this question before you write the rubric.

Where language accuracy fits

If	Then
Sentence-level accuracy is a stated outcome of the course, as in a writing course	Give language its own row, with a weight that matches the outcome. Describe each level by its effect on a reader.
The assignment measures content knowledge, as in a history or biology paper	Give language a small row, or none. If there is no row, do not take points off for language anywhere else.
The writing is low stakes, such as a journal or a discussion post	Consider grading ideas and completion only, and say so.

In every case the principle is the same: one row, one weight, stated in advance.

Six practices

1

Give language one row, and keep it there

When you score the other rows, set sentence-level errors aside. A paragraph with a clear main idea and article errors still has a clear main idea.

2

Describe language by its effect on the reader

“Errors do not affect meaning” is a standard a developing writer can reach and an instructor can apply consistently. “Free of errors” and counts of errors are neither.

3

Write each level as something a student can see or do

Replace adverbs with actions. “Explains how each source supports the argument” can be checked. “Integrates sources effectively” cannot.

4

Show the weights

Put points or percentages on each row. Students use them to decide where to spend their time, and the weights hold you to your own priorities when you grade.

5

Share the rubric with the prompt, and show the top level

The CCCC statement says that, when possible, “instructors should provide students with a rubric that articulates assessment criteria.” An annotated example of strong work shows what the words in the top row mean (Winkelmes et al., 2016).

6

Comment on patterns, not on every error

The CCCC statement recommends “prioritizing two or three mechanical or stylistic issues” for each writer to work on during a course. A student can act on two patterns. A page covered in corrections gives no starting point.

A PRACTICE TO TRY

Score a paper in two passes. On the first pass, read for the argument, the evidence, and the organization, and score those rows. On the second pass, score the language row. This is practitioner advice, not a research finding.

Before and after

Both versions are the language row of a rubric. The second is the one students see on the paired student page.

BEFORE

MECHANICS, 10 POINTS

Excellent: Free of grammatical and spelling errors.

Good: Few errors.

Fair: Several errors.

Poor: Numerous errors that are distracting.

AFTER

LANGUAGE, 20 OF 100 POINTS

Strong: Sentences are clear. Errors are few and do not affect meaning.

Developing: Some errors make the reader slow down, but the meaning is clear.

Beginning: Errors often make the meaning unclear.

What changed

- **"Free of errors" is gone.** The top level now describes clear writing with a few errors, which is what strong student writing looks like.
- **Counts became effects.** "Few" and "several" leave the line between levels to each grader. "The meaning is clear" gives a test.
- **"Distracting" became "unclear."** The first measures the reader's patience. The second measures the writing.
- **The weight is shown as part of the whole.** "20 of 100" tells a student how language compares with everything else.
- **The level names changed.** "Developing" and "Beginning" describe a stage. "Fair" and "Poor" describe a verdict.

Wording you can copy

Replace the text in brackets.

When language has a row

> Language is graded in one row of the rubric, worth [amount]. In that row, I look at whether your meaning is clear. Errors that do not affect your meaning will not lower your score in the other rows.

When language is not graded

> In this assignment, I grade your [ideas, evidence, and organization]. Grammar and spelling are not graded. If a sentence is unclear to me, I will ask you about it.

Level descriptions for a language row

> **Strong.** Sentences are clear. Errors are few and do not affect meaning.
>
> **Developing.** Some errors make the reader slow down, but the meaning is clear.
>
> **Beginning.** Errors often make the meaning unclear.

Links for students

The paired student page teaches the parts of a rubric, how to use the points, and how to read the small words that separate one level from the next. You can add this line to an assignment in Blackboard:

> Before you start, read Reading a Rubric. It shows you how to use the rubric to plan and check your work.

The Assignment prompt builder asks how grammar and word choice count, and adds your answer to the prompt.

Sources

- Conference on College Composition and Communication. (2020). *CCCC statement on second language writing and multilingual writers* (https://cccc.ncte.org/cccc/resources/positions/secondlangwriting). See Part One; "Assessment" in Part Two; and "Response to Student Writing" in Part Four.
- Winkelmes, M., Bernacki, M., Butler, J., Zochowski, M., Golanics, J., & Weavil, K. H. (2016). A teaching intervention that increases underserved college students' success. *Peer Review, 18*(1/2), 31–36.

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The Language of College: A Reading, Writing & Communication Toolkit. Owensboro Community & Technical College.

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